

"Independent India's leaders will neither use a foreign language nor rule from a remote place."

IRON IN HIS SOUL

The source of Vallabhbhai Patel's strength was sacrifice, whether as a young pleader in Borsad or as potential Congress president asked to step aside thrice for his greatest rival and closest comrade, Jawaharlal Nehru

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel

Statesman 1875-1950

■ By Rajmohan Gandhi

To understand Sardar Patel better, let us analyse the two characteristics that everyone associates him with: strength and realism. When Patel died in December 1950, Maulana Azad said the Sardar's valour was "as high as the mountains" and his determination "as strong as steel". Chakravarti Rajagopalachari called him "force incarnate". Jawaharlal Nehru said Patel had been "a great captain of our forces in the struggle for freedom" and "a tower of strength which revived wavering hearts".

The source of Patel's strength was sacrifice, of which a powerful instance was demonstrated in 1905, when he was a 30-year-old pleader in one of Gujarat's small towns, Borsad. Through hard sweat he had put by enough money for a barrister's course in England. A passport and a ticket for the voyage were duly issued to Vallabhbhai Jhaverbhai or V.J. Patel, but the postman delivered these not to him but to his elder brother Vithalbhai Patel, who like the younger brother, went by the name of V.J. Patel. "I am older," said Vithalbhai, "let me go first. You can go later." Not only did Vallabhbhai let Vithalbhai take the ticket and the passport, he also sent money for Vithalbhai's stay in England. In 1910, when he was 35 and the father of

